

Chapter 11: Summing Up

Brief Summary

The final chapter gathers the book's main lessons and reflects on what the Study has contributed after seventy-five years. Vaillant identifies three great contributions: proving that adult development continues across the lifespan, clarifying alcoholism as a major cause of suffering, and documenting involuntary coping mechanisms as real predictors of future adjustment. The chapter is also self-corrective: Vaillant openly notes where his own preferred hypotheses were confirmed, modified, or overturned.

Key Study Findings

- Adult development is lifelong. A poor midlife can improve, a strong midlife can weaken, and people continue to change in love, work, coping, and meaning well into old age.
- Static personality measures and dynamic developmental processes both matter. Vaillant initially favored behavior over inventories, but Extraversion minus Neuroticism at age twenty-one predicted Decathlon outcomes surprisingly well.
- Warm childhood matters, but the positive aspects of childhood predict better than many negative events. Childhood trauma becomes less predictive over time, while childhood love can keep exerting influence.
- Love or attachment remains Vaillant's central answer to what matters most for joy and success in adult life.
- Mature defenses are the second major contributor to good psychosocial outcomes because they support warm relationships and resilient adaptation.
- Mature defenses do not guarantee physical longevity. Vaillant emphasizes that this was one of his own hypotheses that long follow-up weakened.
- Alcoholism is one of the Study's greatest findings because it explains many problems previously attributed to stress, personality, marriage, or social conditions.
- The marriage findings required decades to emerge: 57 percent of divorces involved alcoholism, divorce could lead to happier later marriages, and many marriages improved after seventy.
- Conscientiousness, planfulness, and self-driving traits emerged as important predictors of longevity only after lifetime studies matured enough to reveal them.
- The Study's method - statistics plus life stories - is itself part of the conclusion. Neither numbers nor anecdotes alone are adequate for understanding human development.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- Ernest Clovis is the final major case. His childhood fantasy life becomes mature sublimation through scholarship, teaching, romance, and preservation of French cultural history.
- Clovis also shows the shadow of maturity. His sense of duty and guardianship eventually constricts his creative life, showing that even mature defenses can become limiting.
- Vaillant's own story closes the book. He began with convictions about love, defenses, and development, but the Study repeatedly forced him to refine them. His willingness to be corrected is one of the book's quiet strengths.

Why It Matters

The conclusion is not just a recap. It teaches the central scientific attitude of the book: lives are too long, complex, and surprising to be understood quickly. The best answers require time, humility, and both data and stories.